Building a Recital Programme

Contrasting repertoire, multiple entry points, recovery and an independent next plan.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

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2. Build several paths into a piece
3. Rehearse recovery before performance
4. Make a realistic dress rehearsal
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8. Final programme: chorale, lyrical hymn and flowing hymn
9. Final programme: Holy, Holy, Holy; It Is Well; Come Thou Fount

1. Build a programme with contrast
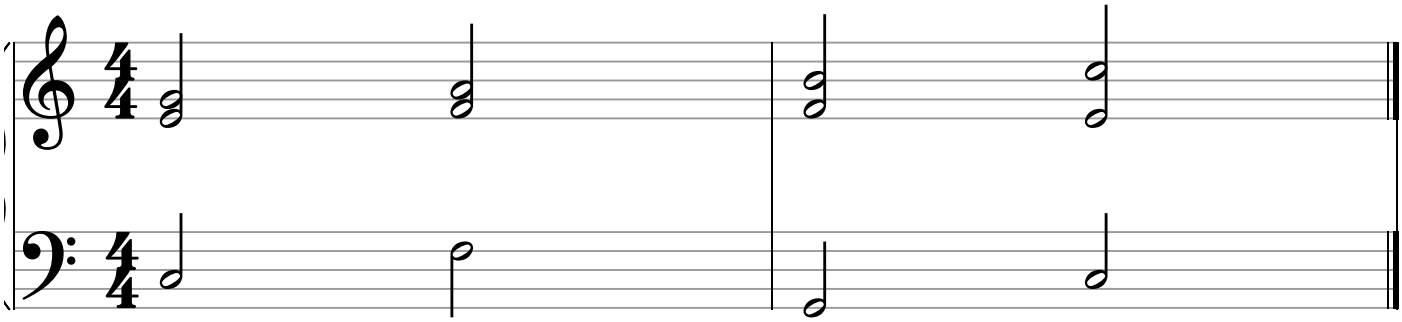
Choose pieces that show different musical strengths.

Build a programme with contrast

A programme should offer contrast without exceeding reliable technique. Combine a clear chorale, a flowing hymn and a lyrical performance. Check the keys, registers, character and duration, and decide where a short silence belongs. Start with something secure. A harder piece is not a better opening if its first movement feels unpredictable.

Practise · A chorale character

Use a broad, clear pulse and a singing upper voice.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A flowing character

Keep the same clear melody above an even, lighter accompaniment.

Practise independently

Write a short programme note for each final hymn: its character, principal technical demand and one intended musical effect. Keep the programme within what you can finish comfortably.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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2. Build several paths into a piece
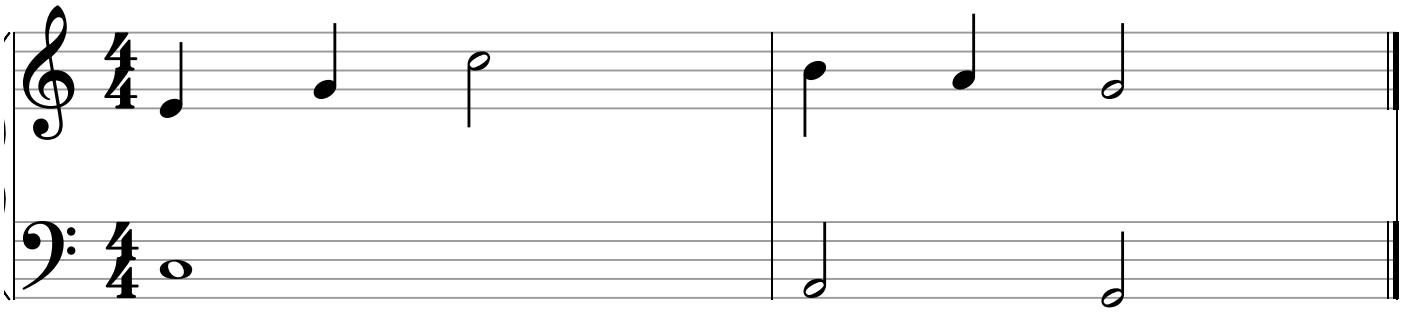
Use harmony, melody and movement instead of one memorized chain.

Build several paths into a piece

Choose phrase beginnings as landmarks and name their bass, melody and harmony. Start from each one without running in from the beginning. Sing the next phrase before playing. Memory becomes more reliable when you can describe the music as well as repeat its movements. Performing with a score remains a valid choice; the goal is secure navigation.

Practise · Landmark one: tonic

Name the first melody note and bass before entering.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Landmark two: dominant

Begin directly on the dominant and hear its arrival at home.

Practise independently

Choose three landmarks in every recital piece. Begin from them in a different order offline and describe the harmony before each entry.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

3. Rehearse recovery before performance

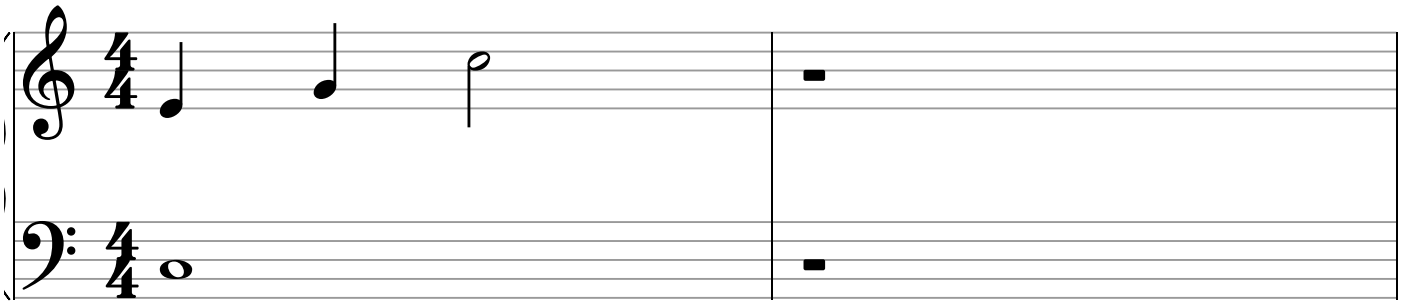
Keep the musical sentence moving after a small error.

Rehearse recovery before performance

A performance is not repair practice. Choose a safe next beat or phrase and continue after a missed note. Practise counting a planned silent bar, then re-entering accurately. Do this away from an ordinary pitch-by-pitch check, which waits for the written notes. Use Flow for a timed reference run and independent practice for deliberate omissions.

Practise · Count through an empty bar

Keep counting during the written silence and re-enter on the next downbeat.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A dependable ending

Practise the final cadence as its own starting point.

Practise independently

Offline, deliberately omit one accompaniment chord while keeping the beat, then continue at a landmark. Restore the full score on the next run. The aim is a calm recovery, not rehearsing wrong notes.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

4. Make a realistic dress rehearsal

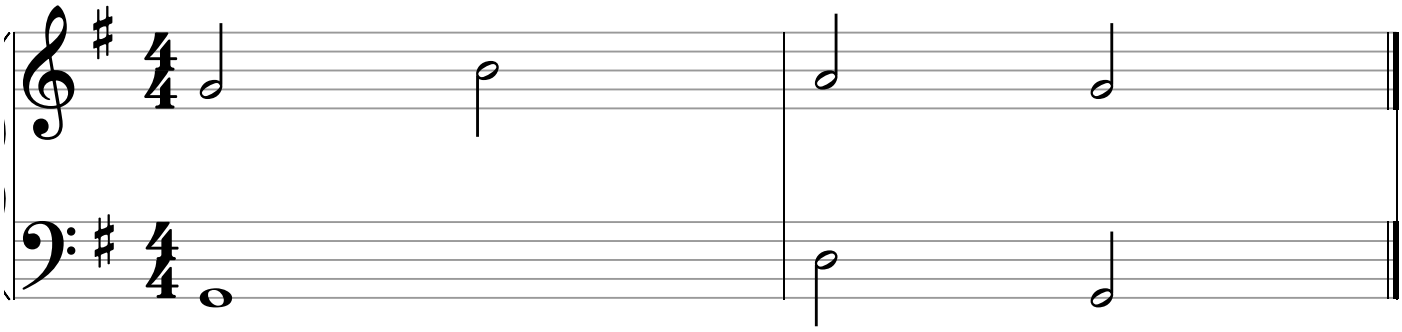
Test the whole routine, including starts, pauses and endings.

Make a realistic dress rehearsal

Set the bench, choose the score display and prepare the pedal before beginning. Announce the first piece if useful, take a quiet breath and start from silence. Play the complete programme without adjustments between phrases. Leave a short pause between pieces. Afterwards review the musical result, not only the number of missed notes. Test the same instrument and room when possible.

Practise · A prepared start

Count a silent bar before your first attack. Let both hands begin deliberately.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A deliberate ending

Keep the final chord sounding, then release hands and pedal together offline.

Practise independently

Run all final pieces, including the spaces between them, at your piano. Record the programme if possible. Choose at most two repair passages before the next full run.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

5. Continue as an independent pianist

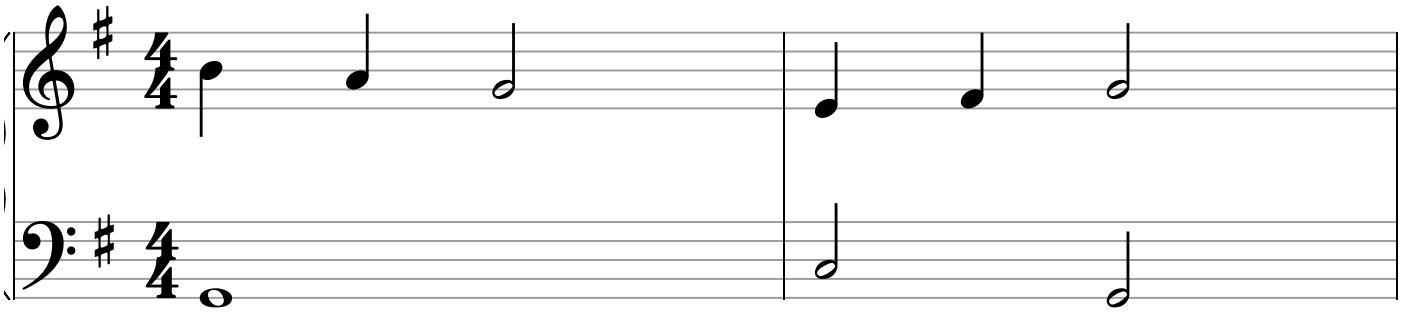
Choose new repertoire and a sustainable next study plan.

Continue as an independent pianist

After this course, choose music by reading a sample, listening to its demands and identifying one manageable stretch beyond your current skill. Keep technique, sight-reading, ear work and repertoire in the weekly routine. A teacher or experienced musician can hear voicing, tension and ensemble issues that a note checker cannot judge. Use feedback to choose your next goal rather than simply seeking harder notes.

Practise · Read, analyse, then play

Name the key, bass route and phrase ending before beginning.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · One final musical sentence

Choose a destination and make the accompaniment serve it.

Practise independently

Choose one new public-domain hymn, make a source note, preview its demands and plan a week of study. Include one listening goal, one technical repair, one ear task and one complete performance.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

6. Dress rehearsal: a broad chorale

Play the entire hymn without stopping. Make the top line sing and keep the inner support light.

Prepare the score

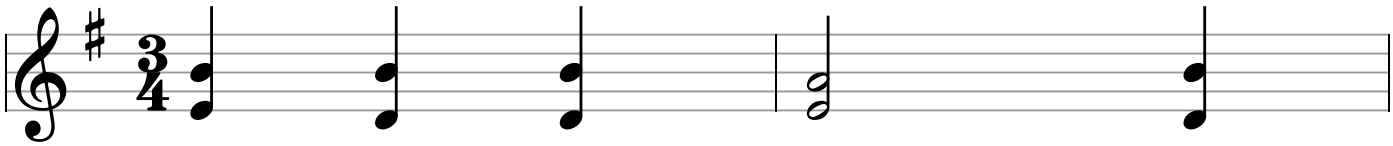
Play the entire hymn without stopping. Make the top line sing and keep the inner support light.

This is a melody-led piano reduction: supporting tones change with the melody. Source inner voices may be moved by octaves or rearticulated; study their original rhythms using the source score.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Play the entire hymn without stopping. Make the top line sing and keep the inner support light.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: a broad chorale

Play the entire hymn without stopping. Make the top line sing and keep the inner support light.

Make your own musical decision

Name the start, middle and final-cadence landmarks. Begin from each in a different order, then make one complete run.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

7. Dress rehearsal: flowing movement in F

Keep the eighth-note accompaniment even beneath a clear chromatic tune. Prepare the new key

before the first note.

Prepare the score
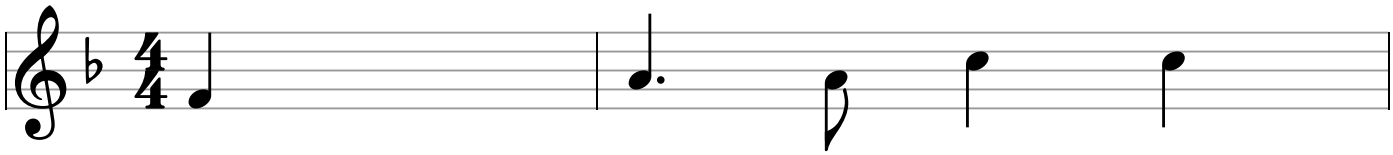
Keep the eighth-note accompaniment even beneath a clear chromatic tune. Prepare the new key before the first note.

The left-hand pattern samples the retained source harmonies at each eighth note. It is an original piano accompaniment.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Keep the eighth-note accompaniment even beneath a clear chromatic tune. Prepare the new key before the first note.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: flowing movement in F

Keep the eighth-note accompaniment even beneath a clear chromatic tune. Prepare the new key before the first note.

Make your own musical decision

Record the whole performance. Choose one movement repair and one musical change, then test both in the complete phrase.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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8. Final programme: chorale, lyrical hymn and flowing hymn

Perform three complete contrasting hymns with a short silence between them. Show a clear melody, reliable pulse, comfortable movement, clean pedal, planned interpretation and calm recovery. Practise a personal interpretation offline before playing these written reference

arrangements.

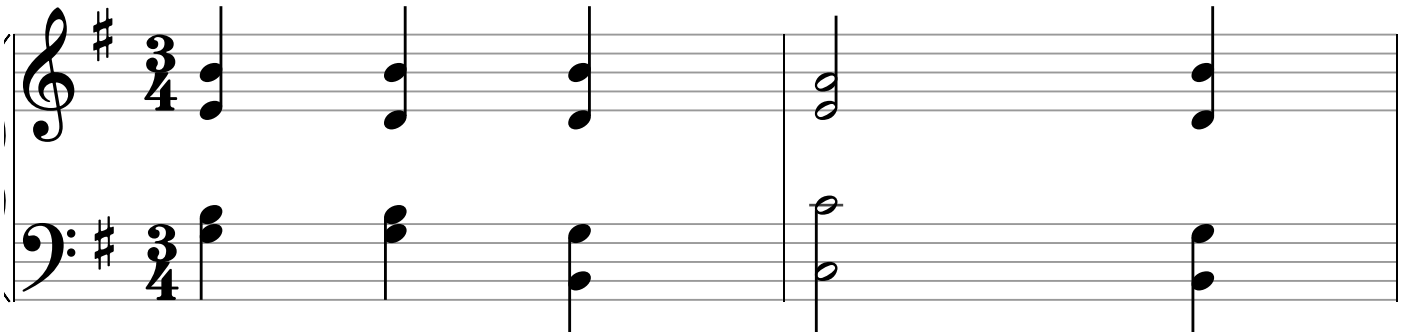
Prepare a complete performance

Perform three complete contrasting hymns with a short silence between them. Show a clear melody, reliable pulse, comfortable movement, clean pedal, planned interpretation and calm recovery. Practise a personal interpretation offline before playing these written reference arrangements.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Jesus, the Very Thought of Thee

Perform three complete contrasting hymns with a short silence between them. Show a clear melody, reliable pulse, comfortable movement, clean pedal, planned interpretation and calm recovery. Practise a personal interpretation offline before playing these written reference arrangements.



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Abide with Me

Perform three complete contrasting hymns with a short silence between them. Show a clear melody, reliable pulse, comfortable movement, clean pedal, planned interpretation and calm recovery. Practise a personal interpretation offline before playing these written reference arrangements.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Eternal Father, Strong to Save

Perform three complete contrasting hymns with a short silence between them. Show a clear melody, reliable pulse, comfortable movement, clean pedal, planned interpretation and calm recovery. Practise a personal interpretation offline before playing these written reference arrangements.

Practise · Performance 1: Jesus, the Very Thought of Thee

Perform three complete contrasting hymns with a short silence between them. Show a clear melody, reliable pulse, comfortable movement, clean pedal, planned interpretation and calm recovery. Practise a personal interpretation offline before playing these written reference arrangements.

Practise · Performance 2: Abide with Me

Perform three complete contrasting hymns with a short silence between them. Show a clear melody, reliable pulse, comfortable movement, clean pedal, planned interpretation and calm recovery. Practise a personal interpretation offline before playing these written reference arrangements.

Practise · Performance 3: Eternal Father, Strong to Save

Perform three complete contrasting hymns with a short silence between them. Show a clear melody, reliable pulse, comfortable movement, clean pedal, planned interpretation and calm recovery. Practise a personal interpretation offline before playing these written reference arrangements.

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9. Final programme: Holy, Holy, Holy; It Is Well; Come Thou Fount

Perform all three complete hymns with short silences between them. Contrast a broad chorale, a lyrical line and flowing movement; keep a clear melody, clean pedal, steady pulse, planned interpretation and calm recovery.

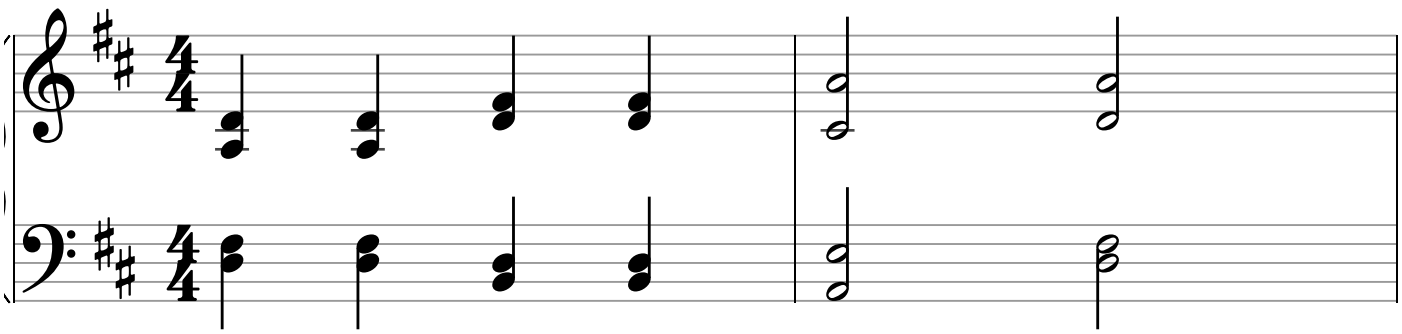
Prepare a complete performance

Perform all three complete hymns with short silences between them. Contrast a broad chorale, a lyrical line and flowing movement; keep a clear melody, clean pedal, steady pulse, planned interpretation and calm recovery.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Holy, Holy, Holy

Perform all three complete hymns with short silences between them. Contrast a broad chorale, a lyrical line and flowing movement; keep a clear melody, clean pedal, steady pulse, planned interpretation and calm recovery.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Dress rehearsal: It Is Well with My Soul

Perform all three complete hymns with short silences between them. Contrast a broad chorale, a lyrical line and flowing movement; keep a clear melody, clean pedal, steady pulse, planned interpretation and calm recovery.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Come Thou Fount

Perform all three complete hymns with short silences between them. Contrast a broad chorale, a lyrical line and flowing movement; keep a clear melody, clean pedal, steady pulse, planned interpretation and calm recovery.

Practise · Performance 1: Holy, Holy, Holy

Perform all three complete hymns with short silences between them. Contrast a broad chorale, a lyrical line and flowing movement; keep a clear melody, clean pedal, steady pulse, planned interpretation and calm recovery.

Practise · Performance 2: It Is Well with My Soul

Perform all three complete hymns with short silences between them. Contrast a broad chorale, a lyrical line and flowing movement; keep a clear melody, clean pedal, steady pulse, planned interpretation and calm recovery.

Practise · Performance 3: Come Thou Fount

Perform all three complete hymns with short silences between them. Contrast a broad chorale, a lyrical line and flowing movement; keep a clear melody, clean pedal, steady pulse, planned interpretation and calm recovery.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Choose pieces that show different musical strengths.
- ☐ Use harmony, melody and movement instead of one memorized chain.
- ☐ Keep the musical sentence moving after a small error.
- ☐ Test the whole routine, including starts, pauses and endings.
- ☐ Choose new repertoire and a sustainable next study plan.
- ☐ Perform my chosen recital with its stated musical goals, clear voicing, reliable pulse, comfortable movement and a deliberate ending.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
